Rugged Individualism

Herbert Hoover · October 22, 1928

Source: Herbert Hoover, "Rugged Individualism" (1928). Public domain. Continuous passage.

> In the closing days of the 1928 campaign, Hoover defended "the American system of rugged individualism" against what he called European "paternalism and state socialism" — a philosophy soon tested by the Great Depression.

We were challenged with a peace-time choice between the American system of rugged individualism and a European philosophy of diametrically opposed doctrines — doctrines of paternalism and state socialism. The acceptance of these ideas would have meant the destruction of self-government through centralization of government. It would have meant the undermining of the individual initiative and enterprise through which our people have grown to unparalleled greatness.

[. . .]

My conception of America is a land where men and women may walk in ordered freedom in the independent conduct of their occupations; where they may enjoy the advantages of wealth, not concentrated in the hands of the few but spread through the lives of all, where they build and safeguard their homes, and give to their children the fullest advantages and opportunities of American life.